

EYE FOR DETAIL

The first time Dinesh Vijan heard the story of *Chhaava*, he liked it. "All of us knew a little about that part of history, but not enough. It's not as if we wanted to make a historical film. But we were clear that it had to be honourable content with wide appeal," says the founder of Maddock Films, the entity that is known for *Stree*, *Stree 2*, *Sky Force* and *Munjya*.

Starring Vicky Kaushal, Akshaye Khanna and Rashmika Mandanna, the film, based on the life of Sambhaji, turned out to be a huge hit. Gautam Dutta, CEO, Revenue and Operations, PVR Inox, says a big reason was the choice of a simple, underexplored character in history. "It was the same with *Mahavatar Narsimha*, where parents took their kids to watch the film."

To Vijan, putting the right actors in "phenomenal stories and if directed by the right captain, can create havoc." He looks at this phase as disruptive, with technology, particularly artificial intelligence (AI), starting to reshape content creation. "Every small content creator is empowered to tell large stories," he says.

Vikram Malhotra, Founder & CEO, Abundantia Entertainment, the company behind *Sherani*, *Chhorii* and *Jalsa*, maintains that 2025 is a year of reset for the Hindi film industry.

"It has been taking place for at least a decade. Now, we are seeing the maturity and sensibility of the audience, along with distinct segments emerging. The one-size-fits-all approach worked as long as options were limited."

THE BIG ONE

On December 5 last year, *Dhurandhar* hit the theatres hoping to capitalise on an important holiday season—the end of the year and



SMALL BUDGET PACKS BIG FAITH

A Gujarati film with a budget of just over ₹1 crore has made over ₹120 crore at the box office, a whopping 11,900% return. That's the story of *Laalo – Krishna Sada Sahaayate*

► Released on October 10 last year, the devotional film did nothing in the first week. Gautam Dutta, CEO, Revenue and Operations, PVR Inox, recalls how he did not even budget a number and was forced to take it off most circuits. Through word of

mouth and private screenings, interest levels gradually took off. "They came back to us two weeks later, and we decided to re-release it," says Dutta. The feedback was so overwhelming that from 17 shows initially, it went up to 370 shows. *Laalo*, released in Gujarat and limited parts of western India, including Mumbai, is the biggest hit from the Gujarati film industry, one that has few releases each year with no big success to speak of.

"We had no money for promotion but knew the story



would catch on slowly," says Ankit Sakhiya, the film's director. He is visibly stunned by the success (at its peak, it did 3,000 shows across all screens) and admits that an unknown film with new faces runs the risk of bombing. For Dutta, the big moment in the film was on a routine morning call with

his team, who said F&B sales had dropped. "It remained our top for the next 14 days, though our F&B took a hit," he says with a laugh.

Laalo is Ankit Sakhiya's debut project, as it is for co-producer Ajay Balvant Padariya. "We put in a little money for promotion but never expected it to be such a big hit," says Padariya. At 32, he is the oldest member of the crew (Sakhiya is 29), apart from being a first-time producer. To cash in on the success of *Laalo* a dubbed version was released in Hindi on January 9.

Christmas. PVR Inox's Dutta remembers the first reaction from the audience. "It was around violence and people saying they didn't want to go for it," he says. But interest picked up from those

seeking action stars, who instead got a well-researched story, strong characters, and great music. "Those who went to watch it for Ranveer Singh and the action instead got a story that was well-researched, with